

Congress will need the support of the Trinamool Congress's 20 MPs. However, what the Congress has lost in numbers it has gained in what Sonia refers to as "the larger perspective". Until now, this was a Government that was tall on promise but short on delivery.

However, by doggedly pursuing the Women's Reservation Bill against all odds, the Congress has achieved the moral high ground on governance. As Jayanthi Natarajan stated in the Rajya Sabha, this was due to "Sonia Gandhi's personal determination". When the bill first came up for discussion on March 8, some Congress MPs were worried that by antagonising both Mulayam and Lalu they would lose their support in Parliament on other bills. Of immedi-

Banerjee—would like the Government to fall just yet; not with the Bihar and West Bengal elections around the corner. Neither would she let her own Railway budget be voted out. Also the BJP, which has just begun the process of getting its house in order after its debacle in the last elections, is not yet ready to face the electorate. After first threatening to bring a no-confidence motion against the UPA, both Mulayam and Lalu soon did a turnaround, perhaps all too aware of the electoral shortfall in their numbers.

The credit claim game too has

begun among the Congress, the Left and the BJP since it is highly unlikely that the three will share the same plank again in the near future. This session has seen some of the unlikeliest of political bedfellows coming together as earlier the BJP had teamed up with the RJD, Samajwadi Party and the Left against the Congress on the price rise. But there is little doubt that while the Left and the BJP got their share of photo-ops, it is the Congress that will walk away with the electoral mind-space. For those worried about losing the minority vote by not giving

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MULAYAM AND LALU
JOINED HANDS
AGAINST THE BILL

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NAJMA HEPTULLAH,
BRINDA KARAT AND
SUSHMA SWARAJ EXULT

ate importance is the finance bill.

With the BJP threatening to bring cut motions on the petro price hike, Congress floor managers are worried that they have some hard negotiating in store. Without the support from the cowbelt parties, the UPA is in a minority in the Rajya Sabha and has only a wafer-thin majority in the Lok Sabha. And everyone remembers the fall of a government in 1998 by just one vote. The PMO is particularly worried about its pet Nuclear Liability Bill that is tipped to be introduced in the Lok Sabha this session.

However, equally persuasive is the argument that no one—least of all

THE ROAD AHEAD

- After the Rajya Sabha, the Government will need a two-thirds majority in the Lok Sabha to pass the bill.
- Of the 28 assemblies, at least 15 need to approve the bill. The Congress, BJP and the Left together rule in 18 states.
- It will then be sent to the President for approval
- 181 of the 543 Lok Sabha seats and 1,370 out of 4,109 Assembly seats will then have to be identified for reservation.

in to the Yadavs' demands, Sonia points out, "Who prevents them from giving tickets to OBCs or Muslim women?" In the end it was a terse missive from Sonia that left the Congress with no option but to push the bill through, and without taking up the cowbelt compromise offer of watering it down to 20 per cent.

The first historic step has been taken. More than just empowering the women, the UPA seems to have empowered itself with a new credo—that it is a Government that delivers. As for women's reservation in the elected bodies, it is a first step in a journey fraught with uncertainty. ■